The First Epic

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COL-400301

The crowds in Chandigarh are gathered around a small roadside stall.

Kanjira: My dear guest, which of these cards is the queen of spades?

Three playing cards are laid out face down on a cardboard box between Kanjira and Ajar.

Ajar: It's ... the one in the middle!

Kanjira: Argh, you've got me again! This is indeed the queen of spades.

Ajar: Haha, I've been watching like a hawk!

Kanjira: Here are the 30 rupees, well-deserved it is, too!

Ajar: How about another round?

Kanjira: Have mercy. You've already bested me three times.

Kanjira: I will not gamble with you again. Not everyone is so clever like you.

The two pretend to be mere strangers, waiting for a victim.

Ajar: Alright then. Maybe you'll make your money back from someone else?

Kanjira: Trust not luck, but your eyes. Anyone interested play cards with me?

Newsboy: Count me in, then?

Kanjira: Welcome, welcome. Please come forward, my dear guest.

Kanjira: The rules are simple. Three cards, one is the queen of spades, and the other two are diamonds.

Kanjira: Keep your eyes glued to the queen. Don't be distracted by the two "little guards."

Newsboy: I've got it all. Just begin.

Kanjira: I like your confidence! The celebration for Dīpa Festival's Eve coming. What do you say ... we make a larger bet?

Newsboy: How large?

Kanjira: 100 rupees a round.

Newsboy: You're on. Hurry up and shuffle the cards.

Kanjira: Can't wait to win big? Then, keep your eyes peeled.

Kanjira: Watch the queen, and fortune shall follow!

Punji: *Hiss*

Kanjira's nimble fingers move the three cards so fast that they almost leave images of themselves in their wake.

Kanjira: Well then, which card is the queen of spades?

Newsboy: ...

Kanjira: Looks like you always stares two cards on the left.

Kanjira: Is it the one in the middle, or the one on the left?

Beguiling the audience with words is much more important than sleight of hand, whether it be on the streets or in the palace.

Newsboy: Neither.

Kanjira: Eh, how can that be? These two cards on the left, I moved them most often.

Newsboy: They are just guards. They patrol here and there to confuse me.

Newsboy: This card on the right is the big one—the queen behind the scenes.

Kanjira covers the card with her hands, as if ready to flip it over.

Kanjira: Are you so sure? This is your last chance. Are you sure?

Newsboy: Yes, flip it over.

Kanjira: Ahem! Er, alright then, you win.

Kanjira doesn't flip the card over, as the loss is in the cards.

Kanjira: You won fair and square. Here, 100 rupees.

Kanjira: Ah, what a bad luck day! That's it for the day, folks.

Kanjira: The show's over, everyone. I don't planning to go broke today.

The crowd laughs and disperses, leaving Ajar and Kanjira behind.

Ajar: Hey, hey! Boss, that wasn't what we rehearsed!

Ajar: Didn't you already use the Three-Card Monte to swap the queen out?

Kanjira: Hmph, kid. Your patience could use a lot of improvement.

Punji: *Hiss*

Kanjira: Great job, Punji!

Kanjira: That kid didn't find the queen.

Ajar: Then what card was it on the far right?

Kanjira: The guards walk walk to confuse him. The queen has long fled the palace with her king.

Ajar flips over the card on the far right to reveal seven of diamonds. Beneath it is another card with a brown back.

Kanjira: Hm? A small card with some pattern? This looks like a limit edition card, from a picture book.

Kanjira: U-T-T-U ... Is this a real word? Ms. Sherjah did never teach me this.

Ajar: Is this really worth 100 rupees?

Kanjira: Hmph! You is so short-sighted! This is just bait to reel a big catch in.

Kanjira: Come on, keep up! I want to see what this "UTTU" is up to.

To the Forest

COL-400302

Kanjira and Ajar hide themselves behind the corner of the street, observing a few familiar figures standing by the newsboy.

Ajar: Kaalaa Baunaa, Matilda, Shamane! What are they ...

Ajar: Ugh, mmph!

Kanjira: Shh! Keep it down!! They're walking our way. Don't let them discover us.

Kanjira turns to silence Ajar by putting a hand over his mouth.

Kanjira: Hm? Where did they go?

Shamane: Hey! Kids, what are you doing sneaking about here?

Ajar: Whoa! You scared the hell out of me!

Kanjira: We ... Uh ...

The girl thinks for a split second before looking up.

Kanjira: W-we agreed to walk Government Square together, but you sent us away!

Ajar: Hm? Didn't we tail th- ...

Kanjira: Ahem!

Ajar clams up and looks rather bemused, having not understood any of Kanjira's pointed looks.

Kanjira: Uh, are you also here to join this topsy-turvy gathering?

Matilda: This isn't a "topsy-turvy" gathering! UTTU Flash Gathering's a famous event amongst arcanists!

Kanjira: Flash Gathering? Sounds like ...

Ajar: Sounds like something that'd fetch a lot of money!

Matilda: It's a reading event! But you're not wrong. Knowledge is the most valuable thing of all!

Shamane: The theme of this one is the Ramayana. Uh, how should I put it? An absolute classic.

Kanjira: Rama? Oh, what is he look like? I may saw him before.

Shamane: Oh? Hahahaha. What a lot of people you must know.

Matilda: Rama is a great character worshipped in the legend! How could you possibly know him?

Kanjira: Uh ... Hmph, I mean, I must saw picture of him in books, if ... if ... he's as famous as you say.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Kanjira's right. Everyone in this land has seen Rama, in books, in temples, and in their dreams.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Now, people from other lands are here for the event to listen to the Ramayana, to hear about Rama's story.

Matilda: We've just finished FLASH: FAME. Look, it even comes with a card.

Ajar: Oh! This card ...

Matilda: This is a FAME Card with information on an arcanist! FAME Cards are a "hard currency" of sorts, and the rare ones are priceless!

Shamane: That's a fresh perspective. I mean, look at these tourists!

Kanjira: Oh! Hey, that's it! Take us with you!

Matilda: Not so fast! The venue is too elusive. We can only find it according to the hints in FLASH: FAME.

Kanjira: Heh, not a big deal. Leave it to clever Kanjira here!

The Monkey Kingdom

COL-400303

Kanjira: These words ... Um ... They look like nothing I seen before.

The girl nods and makes a fair comment.

Kanjira: I can't believe ... Kaalaa Baunaa, can you really read these words?

Kaalaa Baunaa: It's no easy task to read Sanskrit. I didn't imagine that my study of astronomy would come in useful like this.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Luckily, it has its uses, like now. The part about the Golden Deer in UTTU: FLASH is really interesting.

Kanjira: Oh, that bad bad Ravana the Demon King! He lured them away, then he used a dirty ploy to kidnap Rama's wife, Sita ...

Ajar: Yeah, just as cunning as Boss!

Kanjira: What did you just say?

Ajar: Ow! My bad, my bad, don't pinch me!

Ajar: But I prefer the Divine Vanara, Hanuman!

Kanjira: Oh yeah! He's really cool! There's nothing he can't do!

Kaalaa Baunaa: That's why all children love him!

Kanjira: The Demon King wanted to catch Hanuman, but he was asking for trouble! Hanuman ran away, then, told this to Rama!

Kanjira: The great Rama got the news. He will never forgive the Demon King.

Ajar: Then what happened next?

Shamane: Rama went to seek the aid of an all-powerful ...

Kanjira: Stop! No spoilers.

Shamane: Heh! You can't even read Sanskrit. What difference does it make whether it's Kaalaa Baunaa or I telling you?

Kanjira: Reading and hearing are different!

Kanjira: Then, Rama must go cross the sea and revenge on the Demon King?

Shamane: Uh ... My lips are sealed. Can't say a word!

Kanjira: You ...! Never mind. Forget I asked.

The man roars with laughter and pats the girl on her shoulder. Then, he looks at the adjacent building.

Shamane: Look at these event venues. They're as amazing as Rama's palaces.

Kanjira: You is right. Mor Pankh don't have buildings like this.

Kaalaa Baunaa: This place is called the City of Dreams.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Architects from all over the world were invited to Chandigarh and worked with the locals to construct this extraordinary city.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But I think the reason why it's called the City of Dreams lies beyond its unique planning.

Kaalaa Baunaa runs a hand over the wall beside her.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It's because this is a city that reflects the longing of its people for a good life.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Everyone's embraced their past and turned their gaze to the future. Dīpa Festival has not been forgotten in Mor Pankh. This place is as lively as ever.

Kaalaa Baunaa: The old and new meet here, like two planets that brush shoulders with each other.

Kanjira: A gathering like this ... More buildings, more stories, um ...

Kanjira: Come on! I can't wait to read next chapter!

The Nectar of Immortality

COL-400304

Kanjira: The Demon King is unbelievable. He's got ten heads.

Kaalaa Baunaa: The Nectar of Immortality has made the Demon King almost impossible to kill, and these ten heads represent his ten vices.

Shamane: My master once told me that everyone has ten heads.

Kanjira: For real ...!?

Shamane: Ahem! Question! Why did Rama seek penance after cutting off the Demon King's heads?

Matilda: I know! Uh, the text says, "Rama sought penance, for he had taken a life."

Kanjira: But he killed the Demon King, right?

Kaalaa Baunaa: When Rama killed the Demon King, he also killed a "mortal."

Shamane: Because the Demon King himself was also a king, a scholar, a faithful devotee, and a mortal.

Kanjira: What do you mean?

Shamane: His ten heads represented jealousy, greed, selfishness ... All of these are the vices of mortals.

Shamane: He despised mortals, so he did not seek divine protection against mortals' harm.

Kaalaa Baunaa: But eventually, it was Rama, a mortal, who overcame his vices and killed him—the mortal killed the mortal.

Shamane: Not bad. This is also my understanding of the Ramayana.

Kaalaa Baunaa: It's said that Valmiki, the author of the Ramayana, once made a living as a pickpocket.

Kanjira: ...!

Kaalaa Baunaa: But one day, realization struck. He began to gather tales about Rama and edited them into a collection.

Kaalaa Baunaa: He wrote the Ramayana and read it aloud before Rama.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Rama promised Valmiki that so long as the mountains and seas endure, so long shall the Ramayana be read by men.

Shamane: Haha, it's never too late to "cut off the heads."

Kanjira: Uggh ...

The girl looks out into the distance, her face inscrutable. On the street corner, a familiar figure melts into the lively crowd.

Kanjira: It's the newsboy.

She hesitates for a second and dashes to the street corner.

Kaalaa Baunaa: Kanjira?

Kanjira: I returning something to him. Be right back!

The group watches her disappear around the corner and sighs in resignation.

Shamane: Ha, that girl always does things on the spur of the moment.

Ajar: ... Oh!

The boy standing aside raises his eyebrows and bursts into laughter, as though he has realized something.

Ajar: I think Boss is ready to "cut off the heads"!